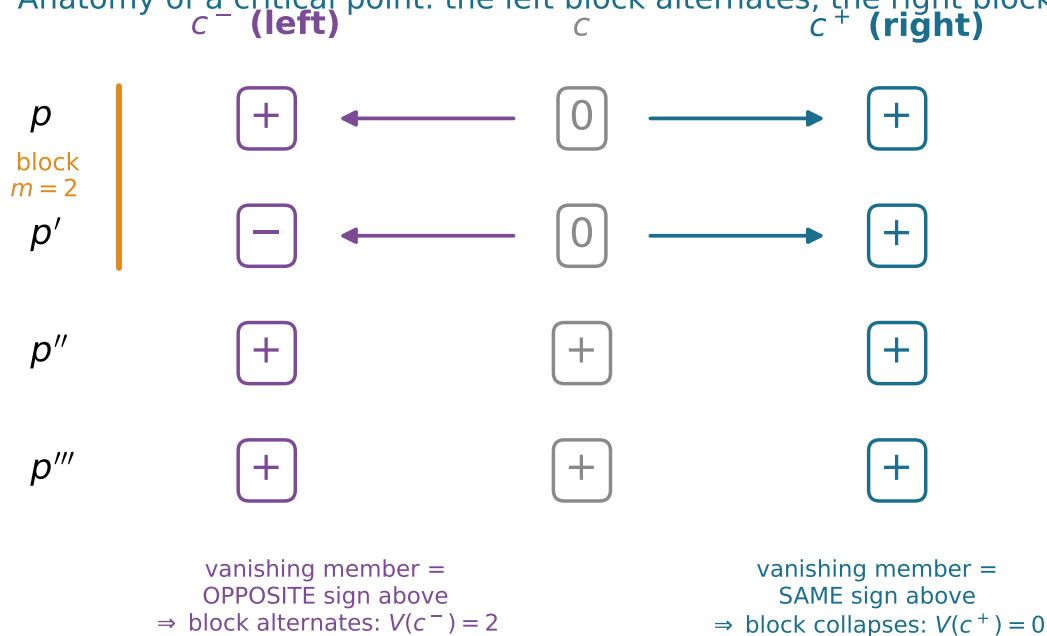


Anatomy of a critical point: the left block alternates, the right block collapses



$V(c^-) - V(c^+) = m = 2$  (root multiplicity), plus an even surplus from interior blocks